

Translation Lens

Please read this before installing.

What it does:

Translation Lens is a small floating window you park over foreign language text - a comic panel, a web page, a PDF. Let go, and it reads the text underneath and shows you:

- How to pronounce each word
- What each word means
- Speaker button to hear it spoken aloud

Languages:

Chinese (Mandarin), Japanese, Korean, French, Spanish, Italian, German, Portuguese, Czech, Turkish and Latin.

- Chinese reads both simplified and traditional characters. Every language gives you pronunciation and definitions.
- All of them can be spoken aloud except Latin - macOS provides no Latin voice, so Latin entries show definitions only, with no speaker buttons.
- A note on Czech and Turkish: macOS text recognition has no dedicated mode for either language, so accented letters (č, ř, ů, š, ě, ě) are sometimes read without their accents. Translation Lens compensates by matching words both with and without accents, and most words still resolve - but expect it to be a little less reliable than the other nine.
- It is a reading aid, not a sentence translator. It looks words up individually and shows their pronunciation and dictionary definitions which is what helps you learn. It does not produce fluent translations of whole sentences.

Everything runs on your own Mac. No account, no internet connection, and nothing you look at is ever uploaded.

Before you install - please check

1. Your Mac's chip (this one matters) Apple menu → About This Mac. Look at "Chip". You need Apple silicon - M1, M2, M3, M4 or newer. If it says "Intel", this version will not run on your Mac.
2. Your macOS version (same window) - you need macOS 12 (Monterey) or later.
3. Disk space - About 140 MB once installed. The dictionaries are included, which is why it works offline.

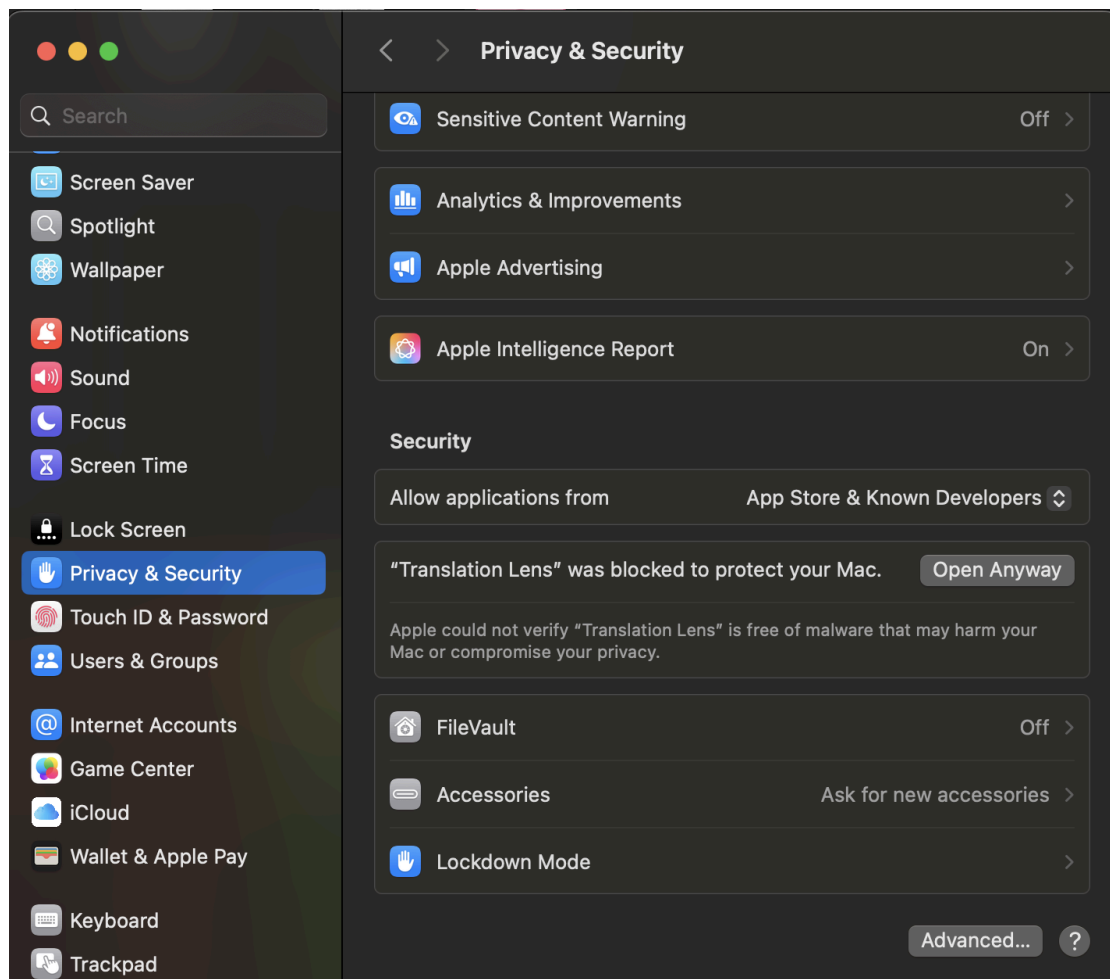
How to install

1. Double-click the .dmg file you downloaded.
2. A window opens with the Translation Lens app and an Applications shortcut. Drag the app onto Applications. If it doesn't show up, drag it into Applications folder manually.
3. Eject the disk image - click the eject arrow next to it in Finder or on Desktop.
4. Open Applications and double-click Translation Lens.
5. Please don't skip step 2. If you run Translation Lens straight from the disk image window, macOS will not remember the Screen Recording permission - the disk image is read-only and its location changes each time you open it. The app will keep asking for a

permission you have already granted. Dragging it to Applications first avoids this completely.

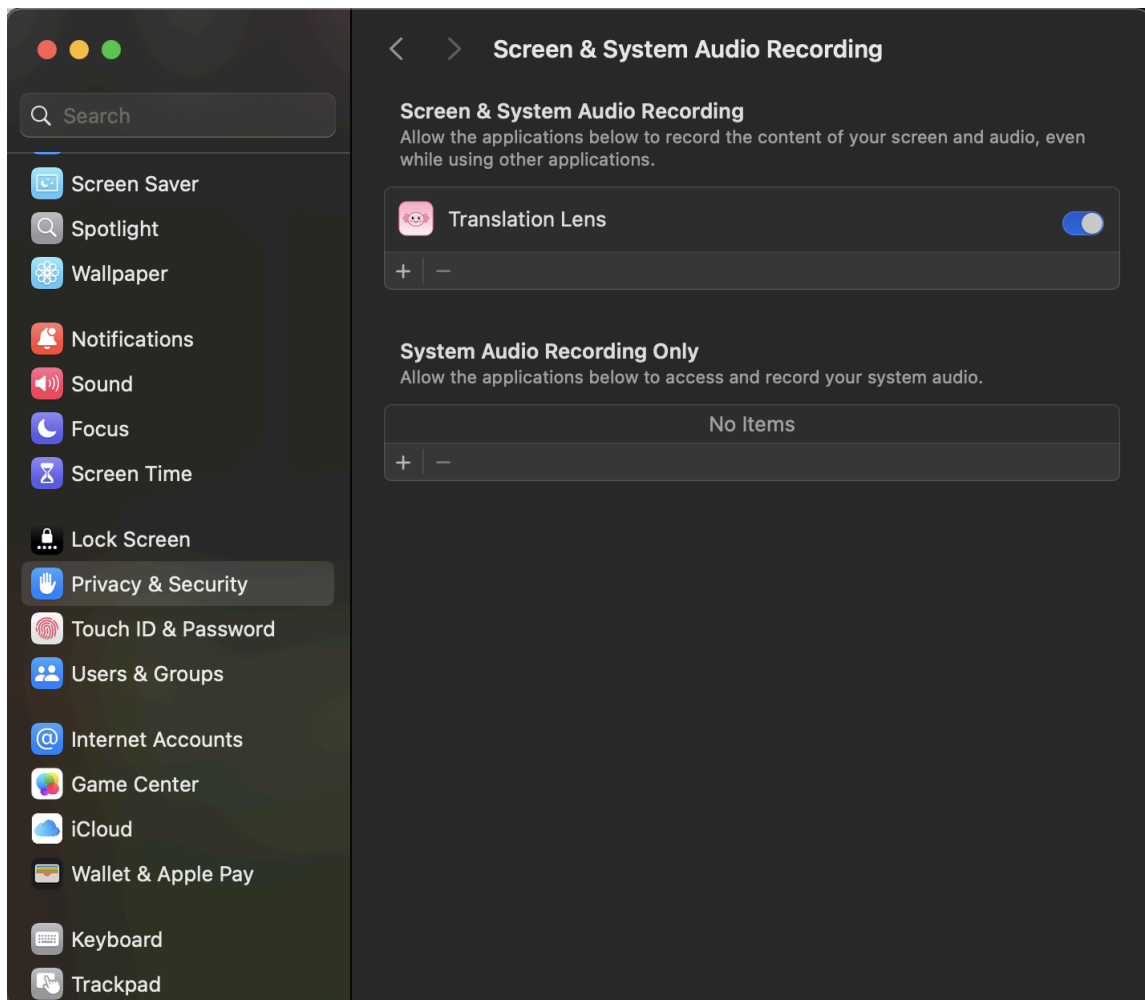
First launch - two things to expect

1. “Apple could not verify Translation Lens is free of malware”
 - This appears because the app is not yet notarized by Apple. To open it anyway: Click Done or Cancel on the warning. Open System Settings → Privacy & Security. Scroll down. You'll see a line about Translation Lens being blocked, with an Open Anyway button. Click it. Confirm with your password or Touch ID. You only have to do this once.



2. Allow Screen Recording (required - this is how it reads text)

- The app will ask for Screen Recording permission. This sounds alarming, so here is exactly what it is for. The lens works by looking at the pixels directly underneath its own window - the same thing a screenshot does. macOS calls that permission “Screen Recording”. Nothing is recorded, saved or sent anywhere. It is the only permission the app needs, and without it the lens cannot see the text you point it at.
- When asked, click Open System Settings. Under Screen & System Audio Recording, switch on Translation Lens. Important: quit Translation Lens completely and open it again. macOS only applies this permission when the app restarts.



Using it

- Drag the window over some text, then let go. If it doesn't auto-update, click the search icon at the top
- It reads whatever is inside the dashed frame
- Click a speaker icon: Hear that word spoken. Hold Option while clicking to hear it slowly
- Resize the dashed frame
 - Three small handles sit on the frame: right edge for width, bottom edge for height, corner for both. Make it small to focus on a single character, or wide to take in a whole speech bubble.
- Title bar buttons, left to right:
- Colors - pick an accent color, or any custom color
- Globe - switch language
- Arrows - quick frame sizes (Character / Word / Line / Bubble)
- Lens - read again without moving the window
- Chevron - fold the results panel away
- X - quit

Troubleshooting

The menu bar icon

There is a small pink axolotl at the top-right of your screen, near the clock. Click it for Show Lens and Recenter on Screen. Use it any time you lose track of the window.

"I can't find the window."

Click the axolotl in your menu bar and choose Recenter on Screen.

"I allowed Screen Recording, but it still asks for it."

Almost always this means the app is being run from the disk image rather than from Applications. Quit Translation Lens, eject the disk image, drag the app into your Applications folder, and open it from there. Grant the permission once more, then quit and reopen - it will stick from then on. If you have installed a new version over an old one, macOS occasionally holds on to the previous permission record. Switch Translation Lens off and back on in System Settings → Privacy & Security → Screen & System Audio Recording, then quit and reopen the app.

"It says nothing was found."

Zoom the page in a little. Text recognition needs a reasonable number of pixels per character. Also check the language in the title bar matches the page you're reading.

"The definitions are for the wrong language."

Click the globe button and pick the right one. Your choice is remembered from then on.

"Switching language takes a moment the first time."

Each dictionary loads on first use. Japanese is the largest, at around 460,000 words. It's instant afterwards.

“No sound when I click a speaker.”

Check your volume first. If there is still nothing, you may not have a voice installed for that language - see below.

“The voice sounds robotic. Can it sound better?”

Yes, and it's free. macOS installs only basic voices by default. To get the much more natural ones:

1. System Settings → Accessibility → Spoken Content → System Voice → Manage Voices.
2. Expand the language you want and download any voice marked Enhanced or Premium. Translation Lens picks the best voice you have installed automatically, so there is nothing to change in the app afterwards. The voices it uses are Yu-shu (Chinese), Kyoko (Japanese), Yuna (Korean), Marie (French), Mónica (Spanish), Alice (Italian), Helena (German), Luciana (Portuguese), Zuzana (Czech) and Yelda (Turkish). Latin has no voice on macOS, so it is text only.

“How do I uninstall it?”

Drag Translation Lens from Applications to the Trash. To remove its settings as well, delete this folder: ~/Library/Application Support/ Translation Lens. A note on accuracy: Dictionaries and pronunciation guides are aids, not authorities.

- Words are looked up individually, so a word with several meanings shows the most common ones - context is still up to you.
- Chinese shows every pronunciation recorded for a word, labelled (for example “also”, “colloquial”, “Taiwan”).
- Korean romanization and Japanese conjugation handling cover the common cases well, but not every exception.
- Czech and Turkish rely on accent-insensitive matching, because the text recognizer drops their accents. A letter genuinely misread - not just unaccented - cannot be recovered.
- If something looks wrong, treat the printed pronunciation as the reference - that comes straight from the dictionary.

Version 1.0.0

Requires macOS 12 or later, Apple silicon.

Credits

Dictionary data is used under the Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 licence (CC BY-SA 4.0):

- Chinese - CC-CEDICT
- Latin, Portuguese, Czech, Turkish - WikDict, derived from Wiktionary
- Japanese - JMdict / EDICT, Electronic Dictionary Research and Development Group
- Korean - English Wiktionary, via kaikki.org
- French, Spanish, Italian, German - WikDict, derived from Wiktionary

The dictionary files included with this app are adaptations of those databases and remain under CC BY-SA 4.0. Copies are available on request. See Licenses.txt for the full list, including the software libraries used.

Text recognition uses Apple's Vision framework and speech uses Apple's speech synthesizer. Both run entirely on your Mac